EXAMPLE BRIEFING

podcast-generator

Listen to the research first, then decide what to read

Markdown script
plain text you or an AI assistant writes

→

Local text-to-speech
Kokoro, on your own computer

→

MP3 or narrated MP4
ready for the commute

This video was made by podcast-generator from the PDF and script in the examples folder.

WHY

Too many papers, not enough reading time

- A **7-minute audio explainer** is enough to decide whether a paper deserves a full read.
- Listening fits time that reading can't use: **a commute, a walk, the gym.**
- podcast-generator turns a written script into spoken audio **locally**: no API key, no per-use cost, and scripts never leave your machine.

HOW IT WORKS

A script goes in, audio comes out

1. Script

A markdown file. Plain paragraphs are spoken; headers and notes are not.

→

2. Convert

Kokoro text-to-speech reads it in the voice you choose.

→

3. Listen

An MP3 lands in your outputs folder.

Three ways to run it

From a chat
An AI app such as Claude Desktop writes the script and runs the conversion through the MCP connector.

Watch folder
Drop a script into a folder; a scheduled task converts it (Windows).

Command line
`podcast-generator talk.md`

FROM A CHAT

Ask for a podcast in plain language

Find a recent, technical paper on why language models improve with more data, and make me a 7-minute podcast about it for tomorrow's commute.

I picked “Deriving Neural Scaling Laws from the Statistics of Natural Language” (ICML 2026). I wrote a script, queued it, and started the conversion.

Done. `neural-scaling-laws-language-statistics.mp3`, 7.4 minutes, is in your outputs folder.

Illustrative exchange with an AI assistant that has the podcast-generator connector, condensed from a real session.

THE SCRIPT

Plain markdown, with notes that stay silent

```
# Where Scaling Exponents Come From

**Voice:** af_heart
**Link:**
https://arxiv.org/abs/2602.07488

## INTRO

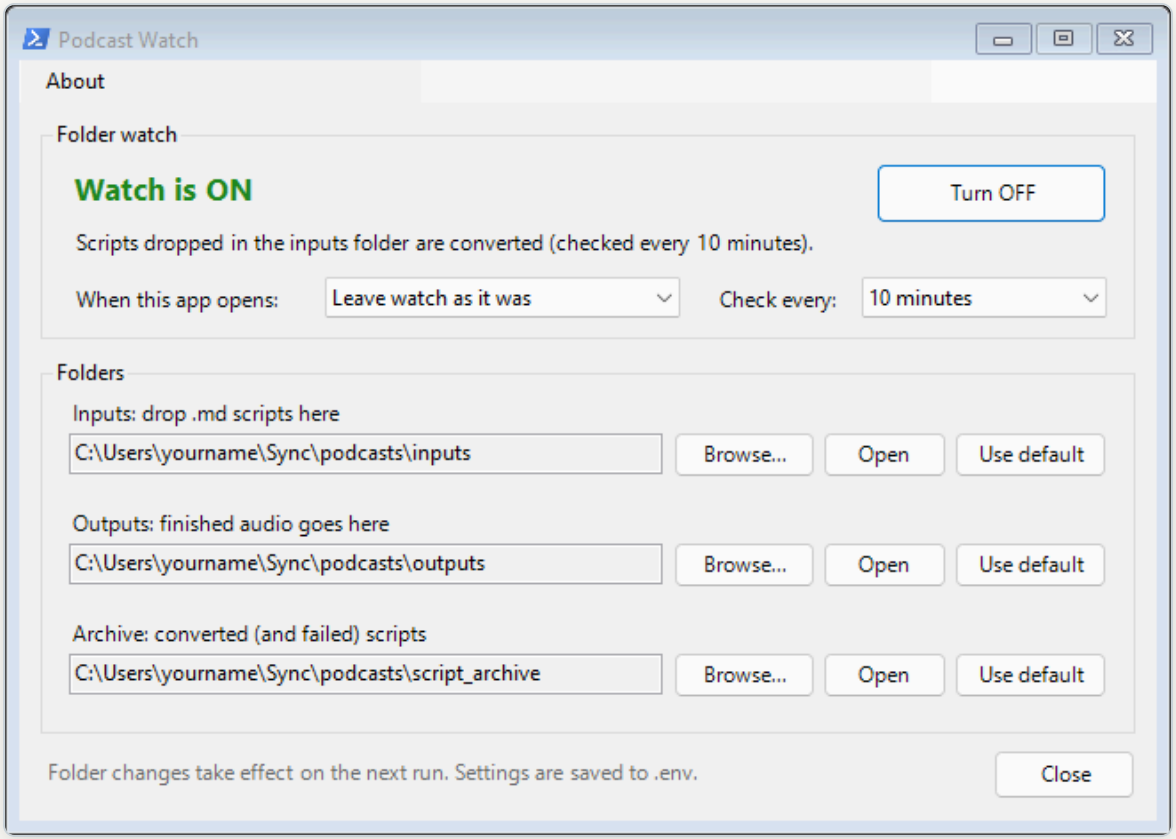
Anyone who follows language models has
seen the plots: test loss falls as a
power law in the amount of training
data.

*Source: Cagnetta et al., ICML 2026.*
```

- **Spoken:** ordinary paragraphs.
- **Not spoken:** headers, `**Key:** value` lines, rules, and italic-only lines.
- A `**Voice:**` line picks the voice.
- **Option:** a `**Voices:**` line turns it into a conversation between two or more speakers, each with their own voice.
- A lexicon file fixes how acronyms are pronounced.

FROM A PHONE

The watch folder: drop a script, get audio back

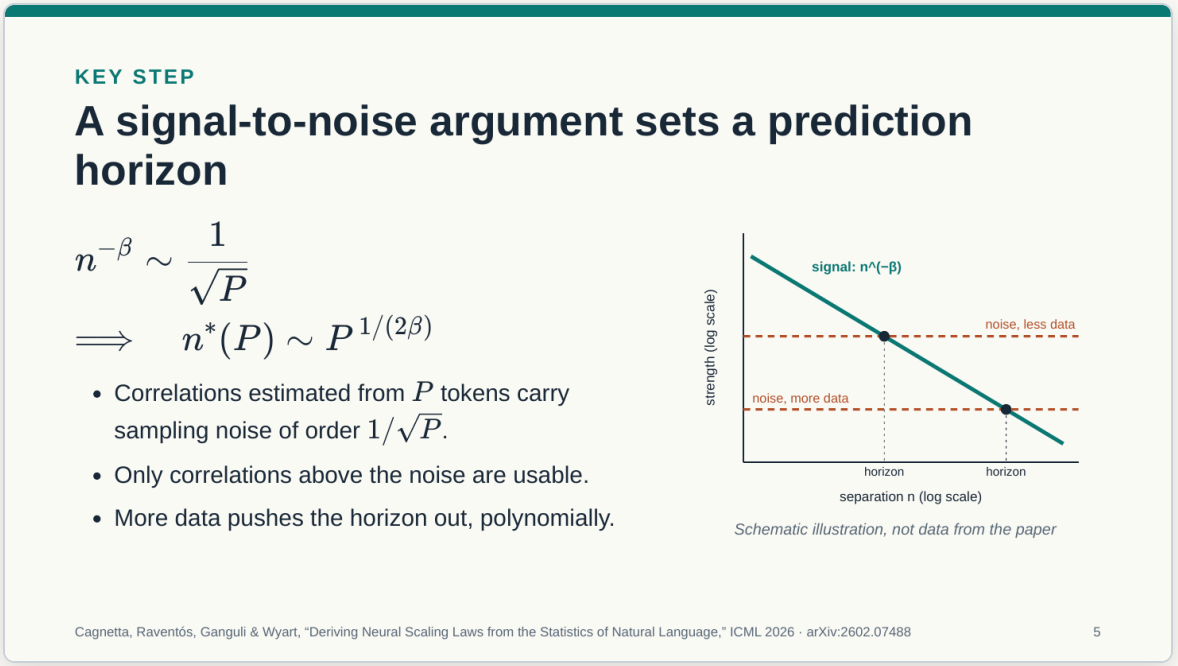


The Podcast Watch app (Windows)

- Point the inputs and outputs folders at a **cloud-synced folder**.
- Save a script there from **any device**, including a phone.
- The watch checks every 5 to 60 minutes, converts what is new, and archives the script.
- The audio syncs back to your phone the same way.

THE LIMIT OF AUDIO

Some papers need to be seen



KEY STEP

A signal-to-noise argument sets a prediction horizon

$$n^{-\beta} \sim \frac{1}{\sqrt{P}}$$

$$\Longrightarrow \quad n^*(P) \sim P^{1/(2\beta)}$$

- Correlations estimated from P tokens carry sampling noise of order $1/\sqrt{P}$.
- Only correlations above the noise are usable.
- More data pushes the horizon out, polynomially.

Schematic illustration, not data from the paper

Cagnetta, Raventós, Ganguli & Wyart, "Deriving Neural Scaling Laws from the Statistics of Natural Language," ICML 2026 · arXiv:2602.07488 5

A page from a narrated briefing on a mathematical paper

- Podcasts work well for surveying **most** papers.
- They work poorly when the argument lives in **equations, charts, or tables.**
- For those, make a **narrated briefing**: each page of a PDF is shown while its narration is read.

NARRATED BRIEFINGS

A PDF plus a page-marked script makes a video

```
# Quarterly review

**Briefing:** q3-review.pdf

## Page 1

Welcome to the quarterly review.

## Page 2

Costs went down this quarter.
```

- A `**Briefing:**` line names the PDF.
- A `## Page N` line starts each page's narration.
- Output: a 1920×1080 **MP4**, subtitles, and a timing file.
- **Strict by design:** a missing or mismatched page marker stops the run with a message, so you never get a wrong video.

HOW TO MAKE ONE

Four steps, done by you or an AI assistant

1. **Set up once:** `pip install "podcast-generator[briefing]"`, and have ffmpeg available.
2. **Get a PDF:** export your slides, or ask an AI assistant to make the deck.
3. **Write the narration** with a `## Page N` line per page: write it yourself, let an assistant with the connector read the PDF and write it, or pull it from PowerPoint speaker notes with `podcast-generator --extract-notes deck.pptx`.
4. **Convert it:** run `podcast-generator deck.md`, drop the script and PDF into the watch folder together, or let the assistant queue it for you.

> Tip: `--preview` prints how long each page will be shown, without making the video.

BEFORE YOU INSTALL

What you need first

- **Python 3.10 or later.** It does not come with Claude or Claude Desktop; install it yourself, or use the uv installer, which can fetch Python for you.
- **About 2 GB of disk space and a one-time download** for the speech model and its libraries. It runs on an ordinary CPU; no GPU is needed.
- **ffmpeg** on your PATH: usually needed for MP3 output, and always for narrated briefings.
- **Internet for the first run,** when the voice model downloads. After that it works offline.
- **Windows** for the Podcast Watch app. The command line runs on other systems too.
- **Claude Desktop,** or another MCP-capable app, only if you want the chat connector.

GET STARTED

Install it and try the examples

```
pip install podcast-generator
```

- **Add-ons:** `[mcp]` for the chat connector, `[briefing]` for narrated videos.
- **Examples folder:** the script and PDF behind this video, plus a sample podcast script.
- **Documentation:** README for a quick start, MANUAL for the full guide.

> github.com/brienalkire/podcast_generator